

DELIVERY

THE CULMINATION OF PREGNANCY AND LABOUR, DELIVERY OF THE BABY AND THE PLACENTA INVOLVES A COMPLEX SEQUENCE OF EVENTS THAT ULTIMATELY SEPARATES CHILD FROM MOTHER, ALLOWING THE START OF THEIR INDEPENDENT RELATIONSHIP.

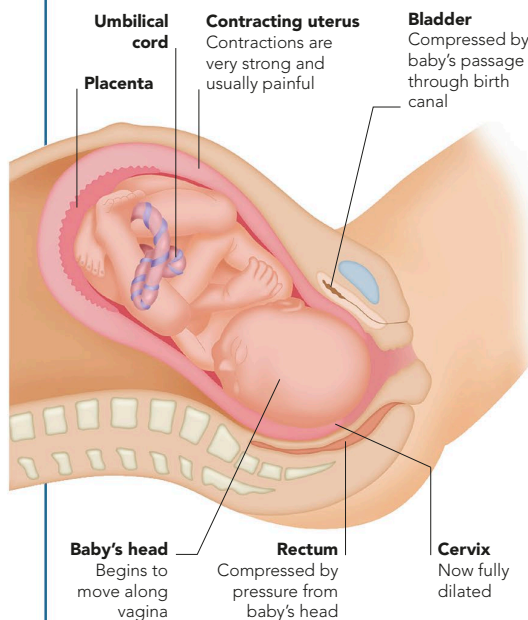
THREE STAGES OF CHILDBIRTH

During the first stage, the cervix dilates and the waters break (see p.269). The second stage, delivery, sees uterine contractions synchronize with shifts in the baby's position as it fits its large head into the birth canal and then travels along it to the outside world. In the third stage, the placenta, or "afterbirth", is delivered, often with the help of a midwife or obstetrician gently pulling on the cord.



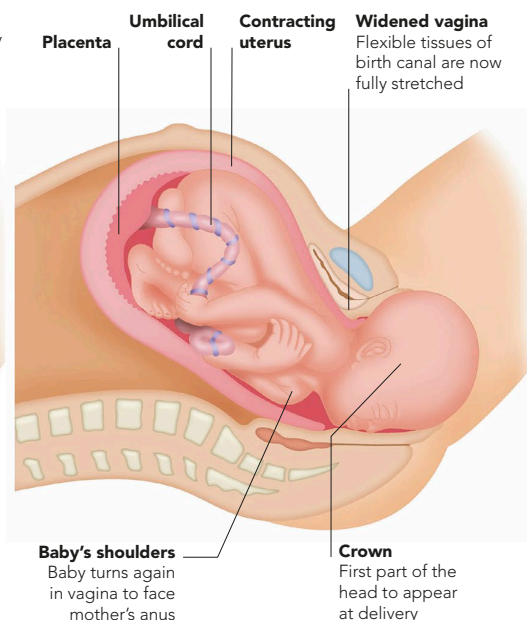
NORMAL DELIVERY

Newborn babies are usually covered with a combination of blood, mucus, and vernix (the greasy covering that protected the fetus in the uterus). This baby's umbilical cord has not yet been clamped and cut.



1 DILATION OF THE CERVIX

When the cervix is fully dilated, the baby turns so that the widest part of its skull aligns with the widest part of the mother's pelvis. As the baby tucks in its chin, it starts moving out of the uterus.



2 DESCENT THROUGH THE BIRTH CANAL

The top of the baby's head appears ("crowning"). Usually, the baby faces the mother's anus, allowing the emerging head to negotiate the bend in the fully stretched vagina. Birth is usually imminent at this point.